

HUSTLE STUDIO · FREELANCER TOOLS

Freelance Client & Invoice Tracker

Know who owes you. Send the right reminder today.

XLSX workbook

Letter + A4 guide

Invoice template

Reminder scripts



Guide for freelance-client-invoice-tracker.xlsx · Tracking tool, not accounting, tax or legal advice. You don't need to print this cover; the guide starts on page 2.

How to use this kit

You get 7 files. Open them in this order:

File	What it's for
freelance-client-invoice-tracker.xlsx	Open first. Your clients, projects, invoices and the reminder emails it writes for you. Excel 2016+ or Google Sheets.
This guide (Letter or A4 PDF)	Setup, the Monday check, the 4 reminder emails, replies to 6 payment excuses, and how to read your numbers.
invoice-template.html / .md	A 1-page invoice to send clients. Open the HTML in a browser, click to edit, print or save as PDF.
reminders-and-replies.txt	Every email and reply from this guide as plain text, ready to copy.
README.txt	The file list, Google Sheets import and support.

Money and currency. Amounts in the workbook have no currency symbol, so they work in any currency. Only the reminder emails show a symbol: the one you type in Settings (default \$).

Sample data. The workbook ships with 5 clients, 9 projects and 8 invoices for a fictional freelancer, Maya Ortiz. Every number in this guide comes from that sample, so you can compare. The sample dates count back from today, so the statuses always look current.

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Set it up in 10 minutes

Four tabs to fill in. You only type in cream cells. White cells are formulas.

Step 1 • Settings (2 minutes)

- **Your name** and **Business name**: they sign every reminder email.
- **Currency symbol**: used in emails only.
- **Monthly income goal** (sample 6,000): the Dashboard and Monthly tab compare against it.
- **Today** is =TODAY(). To test, type a fixed date, then put =TODAY() back.
- **Reminder thresholds** 3 / 1 / 8 / 22 and **Reply window** 5 days. Chapter 3 explains them. The defaults are fine.
- **Late fee in my terms?** Leave it on **No** unless a late fee is written in your contract (see Chapter 5).
- **Win chances** per stage: Lead 20%, Proposal sent 50%, Won / In progress / Done 100%, Lost 0%. Change the % if your own history says otherwise. The stage names stay fixed.
- **The 4 email templates**: rewrite them once in your own voice. Keep the placeholders in curly brackets.

Step 2 • Clients (2 minutes)

One row per client: name, contact first name, email, and where they came from (a dropdown). Type the name exactly as you'll use it on invoices. The **Duplicate check** column says "Duplicate name" in red if a name appears twice.

The white formula columns fill themselves: invoiced, paid, outstanding, overdue, average days to pay, and a **Flag** that says "Ask 50% deposit" when a client has an invoice at the final-notice stage.

Step 3 · Projects (3 minutes)

Every lead and every proposal gets a row, not just the jobs you've won. Type the project, client, stage (a dropdown), quoted fee, estimated hours, actual hours and the date you sent the proposal.

- **Weighted value** = fee × win chance, for Lead and Proposal sent only.
- **Planned rate** = fee ÷ estimated hours. **Effective rate** = fee ÷ actual hours, shown once a project is Done. It turns red when it's below the planned rate and green when it's at or above it.
- **Follow-up** says "Follow up" (amber) when a proposal has waited 5 days or more.

Step 4 · Invoices (3 minutes)

Type the invoice number, client, issue date, terms in days (dropdown: 7, 14, 30, 45, 60) and amount. When money arrives, add the paid date and amount paid. Partial payments are fine: the balance stays open.

Column	What it shows
Check	"Not in Clients" (red) if the client name doesn't match the Clients tab
Due date · Balance	Issue date + terms · amount – paid
Status	PAID DUE SOON (due in 3 days or less) OVERDUE OPEN
Days overdue · Days to pay	Days past the due date · days from issue to full payment
Send this	Heads-up, Friendly nudge, Firm reminder or Final notice

Clear the sample data

On Clients, Projects and Invoices, select the cream sample cells and press Delete. Don't delete the white formula columns. The sample dates are formulas like =Settings!\$B\$9-40, so just type your own dates over them.

Need more rows?

Formulas are filled to rows 5–34 on Clients, 5–54 on Projects, 5–64 on Invoices and 5–19 on Reminders Today. Select the last filled row, copy, select the rows below it, and paste. All totals already count every row down to row 1000.

The 5-minute Monday money check

Same three tabs, same order, every Monday morning. Then close the file and get back to work.

1 • Reminders Today (2 minutes)

This tab lists up to 15 unpaid invoices that need an email today, most overdue first. For each row: click **Email subject**, copy, paste into a new email; do the same with **Email body**; send. With the sample data it shows 4 rows:

Invoice	Client	Balance	Days late	Send this
INV-003	Atlas Legal	1,200.00	26	FINAL NOTICE
INV-004	Lumen Coffee	600.00	14	FIRM REMINDER
INV-005	Atlas Legal	1,200.00	4	FRIENDLY NUDGE
INV-006	Quill Health	1,950.00	0	HEADS-UP

The email already contains the client's first name, the invoice number, the balance, the due date and a pay-by date. You don't fill anything in by hand.

2 • Projects (1 minute)

Look at the **Follow-up** column. Every "Follow up" is a proposal that has waited 5 days or more. Send one short line: "Any questions on the proposal I can answer?" In the sample: **Annual report design** for Harbor & Pine.

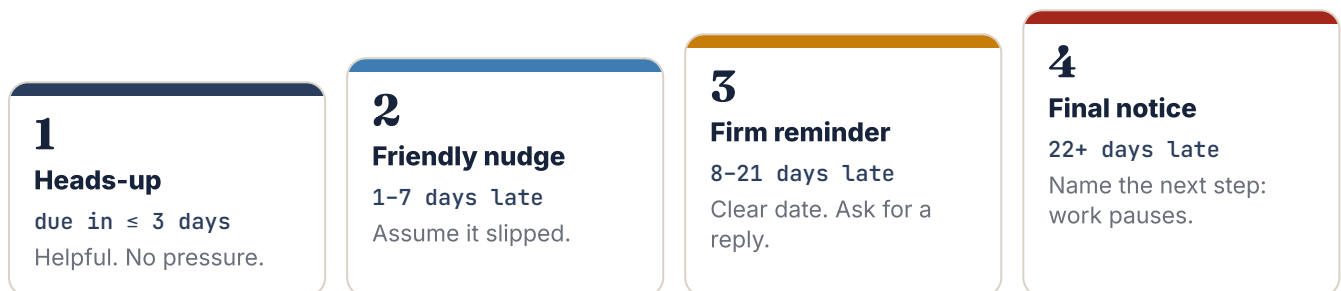
3 • Dashboard (2 minutes)

Read four numbers: collected in the last 30 days against your goal, outstanding, overdue, and the weighted pipeline. If an advice line appears at the bottom, do what it says this week. Chapter 6 explains each number.

The reminder ladder

Four steps, from a polite heads-up to a final notice. The tracker picks the step from the days overdue and fills in the details.

Every unpaid invoice sits on exactly one step. Open **Reminders Today**, copy the subject and body, send. You edit the wording once, in **Settings**, in your own voice.



Thresholds are numbers in Settings (3 / 1 / 8 / 22). Change them and every row updates.

STEP 1 · HEADS-UP

COPY-PASTE · reminders-and-replies.txt

Subject: Invoice {inv} is due on {due}

Hi {first}, a quick heads-up that invoice {inv} for {amount} is due on {due}. Everything you need to pay is on the invoice. Thanks, {me}

Sample: INV-006 · Quill Health · 1,950.00 · due in 2 days

STEP 2 · FRIENDLY NUDGE

COPY-PASTE · reminders-and-replies.txt

Subject: Quick reminder: invoice {inv}

Hi {first}, invoice {inv} for {amount} was due on {due}, {days} days ago. Could you let me know when it's scheduled? If it's already on its way, thank you, and please ignore this. Best, {me}

Sample: INV-005 · Atlas Legal · 1,200.00 · 4 days late

Steps 3 and 4: firm, then final

STEP 3 • FIRM REMINDER

COPY-PASTE • reminders-and-replies.txt

Subject: Invoice {inv} is now {days} days overdue

Hi {first}, invoice {inv} for {amount} was due on {due} and is now {days} days overdue. Please pay the balance of {amount} by {paydate}, or reply with the date it will be paid. Thank you, {me}

Sample: INV-004 • Lumen Coffee • 600.00 left after a partial payment • 14 days late

STEP 4 • FINAL NOTICE

COPY-PASTE • reminders-and-replies.txt

Subject: Final notice: invoice {inv}

Hi {first}, invoice {inv} is now {days} days overdue and I haven't had a reply to my earlier reminders. If the balance of {amount} isn't paid by {paydate}, I'll pause any further work {latefee}. If there's a problem with the invoice, please reply today so we can sort it out. Regards, {me}

Sample: INV-003 • Atlas Legal • 1,200.00 • 26 days late

What the placeholders become

Placeholder	Filled in from	Sample (INV-005)
{first}	Clients: contact first name ("there" if missing)	Marcus
{inv} • {amount}	Invoice # • balance with your currency symbol	INV-005 • \$1,200.00
{due} • {days}	Due date • days overdue	Oct 5, 2026 • 4
{paydate}	Today + reply window (5 days)	5 days from today
{me}	Settings: your name, business name	Maya Ortiz, Maya Ortiz Studio
{latefee}	Empty when Late fee = No. With Yes: " and add [your wording] as set out in my terms"	(empty)

WHEN TO CALL INSTEAD Two emails with no reply, or a balance you can't afford to wait for: pick up the phone before step 3. Then send the firm reminder as a written follow-up of the call.

After the final notice

The final notice names one consequence: you pause further work. Do exactly that if the pay-by date passes. Then pick the next step that fits the size of the balance and the relationship.

1 • Pause the work, in writing

One line: "As mentioned on [date], I've paused work on [project] until invoice [inv] is paid." Don't deliver new files or extra rounds while the balance is open.

2 • Offer a payment plan

If the client says they can't pay in full, offer two or three payments with fixed dates and write them down in an email they confirm. A plan with dates beats an open promise.

3 • Send a formal demand letter

A short letter that states the invoice, the amount, the original due date, the final date to pay, and what you'll do next. In many places this is an expected step before any claim.

4 • Collection agency

Agencies usually keep a share of what they recover. Look up options and fees where you are before you sign anything.

5 • Small-claims court

Many countries and states have a simplified court for smaller amounts. Limits, fees and steps differ a lot. Look up the rules that apply to you and your client.

Stop the next one

The Clients tab flags any client with an invoice at the final-notice stage: "Ask 50% deposit". For that client, the next project starts after the deposit is paid. Chapter 5 has the wording.



Not legal advice. These are options to look up, not recommendations for your situation. Rules on demand letters, collection and courts depend on where you and your client are. If a large amount is at stake, talk to a local lawyer or advice service.

Replies to 6 payment excuses

What the client says, what not to answer, and a reply that gets a date. Words in [brackets] are yours to fill in.

EXCUSE 1

"We're waiting on finance to approve it."

✗ DON'T SAY

"No problem, take your time."

✓ SAY THIS

Thanks for letting me know. Could you tell me who in finance is handling it and the date it's expected to be approved? I'll note it on my side and check back on [date] if I haven't seen the payment.

EXCUSE 2

"The payment is on its way."

✗ DON'T SAY

"Great, thanks!" and then wait another month.

✓ SAY THIS

Thank you. Could you send me the payment date and reference once it's processed? I'll confirm as soon as it arrives. If it hasn't landed by [date], I'll get back in touch.

If the date they gave passes and they still don't reply:

1. The next morning, send the Firm reminder from Reminders Today. Quote their own words and date: "You mentioned payment by [date]."
2. Three working days later, call. A two-minute call settles more than a fourth email. Ask one question: "What date will it be paid?"
3. Still nothing after 22 days overdue: send the Final notice and pause new work for this client (see Chapter 3 for what comes after a final notice).

EXCUSE 3

No reply at all.

✗ DON'T SAY

"Just following up again, sorry to bother you..."

✓ SAY THIS

Hi [name], I haven't heard back about invoice [inv] for [amount], now [days] days overdue. Could you reply with a payment date by [date]? If someone else handles invoices, please point me to them and I'll take it from there.

EXCUSE 4

A partial payment, with no date for the rest.

✗ DON'T SAY

"Thanks for the payment!" and nothing about the rest.

✓ SAY THIS

Thanks, I've received [amount paid] toward invoice [inv]. The remaining balance is [balance]. Could you confirm the date the rest will be paid? If it helps, we can split it into two payments with fixed dates.

In the tracker, type the partial amount in **Amount paid**. The balance, the status and the next reminder update by themselves. INV-004 in the sample is this case: 600.00 of 1,200.00 paid, 600.00 open.

EXCUSE 5

"We weren't happy with the work." (after delivery)

✗ DON'T SAY

"I'll take 30% off." Or: "You approved it, so pay."

✓ SAY THIS

I'm sorry to hear that, and I want to understand. Could you list the specific points that don't match the brief we agreed on? Let's go through them on a short call this week. Anything within the agreed scope, I'll fix. The invoice covers the work delivered on [date], so please let me know when it will be paid.

EXCUSE 6

"Can we pay in 60 days instead?"

✗ DON'T SAY

"Sure, whatever works for you."

✓ SAY THIS

I understand cash flow can be tight. My terms are [terms] days, as agreed. What I can offer is two payments: half by [date] and the rest by [date]. Does that work for you?

Every reply asks for a **date**. Once you have one, type it into your calendar and let the tracker tell you when it has passed.

Get paid on time next time

Most late payments are decided before the work starts: in the deposit, the milestones and the terms.

Ask for a 50% deposit

A deposit tells you the client can pay and is committed. Ask for it on every new client and on every client the tracker flags "Ask 50% deposit".

DEPOSIT WORDING To book your start date, I ask for a 50% deposit. The deposit is credited against the final invoice.

Bill by milestone on longer jobs

For anything longer than a month, split the fee into 2–4 milestones, each with its own invoice: for example 50% to start, 25% at first draft, 25% on delivery. You never carry more than one milestone of unpaid work.

Write the terms down

Put the same short paragraph in your proposal, your contract and on every invoice:

TERMS WORDING Payment terms: 50% deposit due before work starts. The balance is due within 14 days of the invoice date. Invoices are sent on delivery of each milestone.

Pick terms you can live with. The Terms dropdown has 7, 14, 30, 45 and 60 days. Shorter terms mean the reminder ladder starts sooner.

A late-fee clause (example)

A late fee only works if it was agreed before the work started. If you add one to your terms, set **Late fee in my terms?** to **Yes** in Settings. The Final notice will then mention it, using the wording you type in Settings (sample: "a late fee of 1.5% per month").

EXAMPLE CLAUSE Late payments: invoices not paid within [terms] days of the invoice date incur a late fee of 1.5% per month on the overdue balance, starting the day after the due date.

 **Check local rules.** Check that late fees are allowed where you and your client are, and what rate is allowed. Some places set a maximum rate or a fixed statutory amount. This is an example, not legal advice.

Invoice on delivery, the same day

Every day between delivery and invoice is a day added to how long you wait. Make it a habit: the day you deliver, you send the invoice. Use **invoice-template.html**: fill it in, print to PDF, send, then add the row on the Invoices tab.

Make paying easy

- Put the payment details (bank, reference, link) on the invoice itself, not in a separate email.
- Ask who pays invoices on the client side, and send to that person as well as your contact.
- Use the invoice number as the payment reference so you can match payments quickly.

Read your numbers

Four checks on the Dashboard, worked through with the sample data in the workbook.

SAMPLE NUMBERS · FROM THE XLSX · WEIGHTED PIPELINE

$3,000 \times 50\%$ (Proposal sent) + $2,000 \times 20\%$ (Lead) =

1,900

Work you might win, discounted by how likely it is. 1,900 is well below the 6,000 goal, so the Dashboard says: send outreach and follow up on proposals.

BOOKED WORK (WON + IN PROGRESS)

$2,400 + 1,950 + 6,500 =$

10,850

Work that's agreed but not finished: your next months of invoices.

REAL VS PLANNED HOURLY RATE (DONE PROJECTS)

$9,000 \div 110 \text{ h actual} = 81.82$ · $9,000 \div 93 \text{ h estimated} = 96.77$

81.82 vs 96.77

The three finished projects ran 17 hours over (7 + 4 + 6). Quote the next similar job on the hours it really took. Our **Freelance Pricing Kit** covers how to set that price.

OUTSTANDING VS GOAL · COLLECTED

Outstanding 8,200 (3,000 overdue on 3 invoices) · collected last 30 days 4,200 = 70% of 6,000

8,200 > 6,000

More than a month's goal is sitting with clients. The Dashboard says: ask new clients for a 50% deposit.

FAQ

How do I use it in Google Sheets?

In Google Drive: New > File upload, choose the .xlsx. Or in Sheets: File > Import > Upload > choose the file > Replace spreadsheet. Formulas, dropdowns and colours come along. If Sheets asks, allow it to convert the file.

Which currency does it use?

Any. Amounts have no symbol. Type your symbol (€, £, A\$...) in Settings and the reminder emails use it.

I need more rows.

Formula rows: Clients 5–34, Projects 5–54, Invoices 5–64, Reminders Today 5–19. Select the last filled row, copy, select the rows below and paste. Totals already include rows down to 1000. The dropdown comes along with the copied row.

Dates show as numbers, or my Excel isn't in English.

A number like 46304 is a date without a date format. Select the cells and choose Format Cells > Date (Excel) or Format > Number > Date (Sheets). Excel translates function names into your language by itself. The email dates use English month names ("Jan","Feb"...), written inside the formulas of the Due (text) column on Reminders Today and of Settings C40. To use your own language, edit the month names in those formulas, then copy the Due (text) formula down to row 19.

A client name shows "Not in Clients".

The name on Projects or Invoices doesn't match the Clients tab exactly (spaces and spelling count). Fix either one and the warning disappears.

Does it send the emails for me?

No. It writes them; you copy and send them from your own email. No scripts, no add-ons, no account to connect.

Can I add a real chart?

Yes, in about 30 seconds. The workbook has no built-in charts; the Monthly tab shows text bars instead. Monthly isn't locked, so you can add a chart there:

- **Excel:** on Monthly, select A4:C16 (Month, Invoiced, Collected). Insert > Recommended Charts > Clustered Column > OK.
- **Google Sheets:** on Monthly, select A4:C16. Insert > Chart. In the chart editor, set Chart type to Column chart.

The chart updates as you add invoices, because it reads the same formulas.

Why is the Dashboard locked?

So a stray keystroke doesn't break a formula. It has no password. Excel: Review > Unprotect Sheet. Google Sheets: Data > Protect sheets and ranges, then remove the protection.

What do the colours mean?

Colour	Where
CREAM	Cells you type in
WHITE	Formulas: don't type over them
GREEN	Status Paid · effective rate at or above planned · progress at 100% or more
AMBER	Status Due soon · Follow up · Dashboard advice lines
RED	Overdue · Final notice · Not in Clients · Duplicate name · Ask 50% deposit · effective rate below planned

The cell always says the word too, so it reads in black and white.

Can I change the reminder wording?

Yes, on Settings. Keep the placeholders in curly brackets; everything else is yours.

What isn't in the file?

No accounting, no tax, no automatic emailing, no native charts. It's a tracking tool.

PRINT ME · EVERY MONDAY

Monday money check

Week of _____ · about 5 minutes

☐ **Settings:** Today shows today's date (=TODAY()).

☐ **Invoices:** payments received last week entered (paid date + amount paid).
Received from / amount

☐ **Invoices:** every invoice sent last week has a row.

☐ **Reminders Today:** every row sent (subject + body copied).
Sent to / amount
Sent to / amount

☐ **Final notice** sent? Note the pay-by date in your calendar.
Client / pay-by date

☐ **Projects:** every "Follow up" proposal got a short email.

☐ **Projects:** stages updated (won, lost, done) and actual hours on Done projects.

☐ **Dashboard:** collected last 30 days _____ % of goal · outstanding _____

☐ **Advice line** showing? Plan one action for this week.
Action

☐ **Flag "Ask 50% deposit"** on any client? Use the deposit wording on the next project.

Disclaimer

The Freelance Client & Invoice Tracker is a tracking tool, not accounting, tax or legal advice. It doesn't replace bookkeeping software, an accountant or a lawyer. The email templates, replies, terms wording and the late-fee clause are examples to adapt; check that they suit your contract and the rules where you and your client are.

The sample freelancer (Maya Ortiz) and the sample clients are fictional. The numbers in this guide are the sample data in the workbook, not statistics about freelancers.

Support and refunds

Something not working, or a question about the files? Use the support address in README.txt. If the tracker isn't right for you, ask for a refund within 14 days of purchase.

What's in the box

- freelance-client-invoice-tracker.xlsx (8 tabs)
- freelance-client-invoice-tracker-letter.pdf and -a4.pdf (this guide, 18 pages)
- invoice-template.html and invoice-template.md
- reminders-and-replies.txt
- README.txt

Hustle Studio · Charge more. Win better clients. Spend less time on admin.